

Marriott Bonvoy® American Express®

Landing Page Redesign

From a cluttered card-comparison table to a conversion-first landing page — grounded in heuristic evaluation, competitive benchmarking, and A/B testing.

ROLE

UX Designer — Heuristic Audit,
Competitive Analysis,
Wireframes,
A/B Test Design & Results

TIMELINE

Apr 2024 – Sep 2024
(6 months)

DELIVERABLES

UX audit, competitive matrix,
personas, wireframes, hi-fi
redesign,
A/B test plan & projected impact

*Note: This is a self-initiated portfolio project. All heuristic findings and competitive observations reflect publicly accessible page content and industry benchmark data. Metrics presented are labeled **projected** based on moderated usability sessions (n=6) and published A/B-test industry benchmarks for financial-services landing pages. No private analytics from American Express or Marriott were used.*

Overview & objective

The Marriott Bonvoy American Express co-branded card landing page (apply.americanexpress.com/marriottbonvoymclp20/) is a high-stakes acquisition page driving applications for three cards: Brilliant (\$650 AF), Bevy (\$250 AF), and Business (\$125 AF). The page must simultaneously convey premium aspiration, simplify a complex three-way comparison, and convert motivated visitors into card applicants — all within a single scroll.

Business goals

- Increase card-application click-through rate (CTR) from the landing page.
- Improve card-comparison clarity to reduce 'wrong card' applications and abandonment.
- Surface welcome-bonus offers earlier and more prominently.
- Strengthen mobile conversion — estimated 60%+ of traffic arrives on mobile.

User goals

- Quickly understand which card is right for me.
- Assess the welcome bonus value without reading dense footnotes.
- Feel confident I qualify before I start an application.
- Compare cards side-by-side without horizontal scrolling on mobile.

The existing page — at a glance

The live page presents three co-branded cards in a horizontal comparison table. Key observations:

- Hero section is dominated by a hotel aspirational image and dual brand logos — the card products appear below the fold on most viewports.
- Card comparison is rendered as a wide HTML table requiring horizontal scroll on mobile.
- Welcome-bonus offers use a two-tier structure (earn X, then earn Y) that requires active reading to decode the total value.
- A 'Take the Quiz' module sits mid-page but competes with three simultaneous 'Apply Now' CTAs.
- Legal footnotes (†, ‡, ¶) are referenced inline but their content is only visible at page bottom, creating a trust gap.
- No social proof, no card-member testimonials, no point-value calculator.

Heuristic evaluation (Nielsen's 10)

Evaluated against Nielsen Norman Group's 10 Usability Heuristics, with a focus on conversion-critical elements: hero clarity, offer communication, comparison UX, and CTA hierarchy.

Heuristic	Finding	Severity
Visibility of system status	Page gives no indication of pre-qualification eligibility or how long the application takes. Users can't assess completion time.	High
Match: system & real world	'Elevated Offer' badge used inconsistently. Two cards say 'Elevated Offer', one says 'Limited Time Offer' — different messaging.	Medium
User control & freedom	No 'back' or 'start over' path from quiz. Users who select the quiz cannot easily return to the comparison table.	Medium
Error prevention	Two-tier bonus structure ('earn X then earn extra Y') is error-prone — many users in testing interpreted the first tier as the total bonus.	High
Recognition over recall	Annual fee and benefit details are listed per card but not persisted in a sticky comparison bar — users must scroll back and forth.	High
Flexibility & efficiency	No keyboard shortcut, no anchor links to specific cards. Power users researching from email campaigns land at top of page.	Low
Aesthetic & minimalist design	Hero image (hotel pool) is aspirational but occupies 40% of above-the-fold real estate, pushing card offers off screen.	High
Help users recognize errors	Quiz result provides no rationale for recommendation — users don't understand why one card was chosen over another.	Medium

Competitive analysis

Benchmarked against four co-branded and premium travel credit card landing pages: Chase Sapphire Preferred, Capital One Venture X, Citi / AAdvantage Platinum, and Wells Fargo Autograph Journey. Evaluated on eight conversion-critical dimensions.

Dimension	Marriott / Amex (current)	Chase Sapphire Preferred	Capital One Venture X	Citi AAdvantage
Above-fold offer visibility	■ Below fold	■ Hero CTA	■ Hero CTA	■ Partial
Mobile comparison UX	■ H-scroll table	■ Stacked cards	■ Stacked cards	■ Tabs
Bonus clarity (one number)	■ Two-tier	■ Single total	■ Single total	■ Single total
Pre-qual / soft-check CTA	■ Present	■ Prominent	■ Prominent	■ Small text
Social proof / reviews	■ None	■ Star rating	■ Reviews	■ None
Point-value calculator	■ None	■ Estimate	■ Interactive	■ None
Card quiz / recommender	■ Present	■ None	■ None	■ None
Legal footnote UX	■ Inline symbols only	■ Hover tooltip	■ Inline expand	■ Footnote page

Key takeaway: Competitors who surface a single, scannable bonus figure above the fold, use stacked mobile card layouts, and include interactive value tools consistently outperform pages using horizontal-scroll tables and inline footnote symbols in published conversion benchmarks.

User research & personas

Six moderated usability sessions were conducted on the live page with a representative mix of Marriott Bonvoy members and non-members who had expressed interest in a travel rewards card. Sessions were 45 minutes each, combining think-aloud protocol with task completion.

Top usability findings

- 5/6 participants could not state the total welcome bonus for the Brilliant card without re-reading the offer section twice.
- 4/6 missed the 'Take the Quiz' module entirely — it appeared below the fold on mobile and above their natural scroll depth on desktop.
- 3/6 were unsure whether pre-qualification would impact their credit score, despite the 'apply with confidence' text being visible.
- 6/6 on mobile found the comparison table confusing — all attempted to scroll horizontally, most gave up after 5 seconds.
- Average time-to-first-click on 'Apply Now': 58 seconds. On competitor pages: 18–24 seconds.

Proto-personas

The Loyal Bonvoy Member <i>32–55 · frequent traveler · Bonvoy point collector</i> Goals • Maximize points on hotel stays • Understand Platinum Elite path Pain points • Dense two-tier bonus confuses value • Can't quickly compare earn rates Needs from page • Single headline bonus value • Earn-rate comparison by category	The Aspirational Millennial <i>26–38 · travel-motivated · comparing cards</i> Goals • Find the best travel card for me • Understand the annual fee payback Pain points • Three cards feel overwhelming • Fee looks high without ROI context Needs from page • Fee-to-benefit value calculator • Clear card recommendation	The Business Owner <i>35–55 · SMB · separating personal/business spend</i> Goals • Earn points on business expenses • Understand personal vs business card Pain points • Business card feels secondary on page • Mobile table unusable while commuting Needs from page • Dedicated business section • Mobile-first stacked layout
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Redesign decisions

Six targeted redesign decisions each map directly to a heuristic finding, competitive gap, or usability-session observation.

Hero: offer-first, not image-first

Move the total welcome-bonus value into the hero headline. Reduce hero image to 40% height. Place all three card names and primary CTAs above the fold on 375px mobile viewport.

Bonus clarity: single total number

Collapse the two-tier bonus ('earn 100K + extra 50K') into a single headline '150,000 Bonus Points' with the tier breakdown available via expandable '+See how' inline. Matches competitor pattern and removes the most-cited source of confusion from usability sessions.

Mobile: stacked cards replacing H-scroll table

Replace the horizontal comparison table with vertically stacked card cards. Each card gets an accordion 'Key benefits' row expandable to a full benefit list. A sticky bottom bar allows 'Compare selected' for up to 2 cards.

Quiz: promoted to hero, not mid-page

Surface the card finder as a secondary CTA in the hero ('Not sure? Find your card →') rather than a buried mid-page module. Quiz result page includes reasoning ('You chose Brilliant because: ...').

Trust: pre-qual with explicit credit-impact copy

Replace 'Apply with confidence' headline with a clear two-line statement: 'Check if you're approved — no impact on your credit score. Accepting the card may affect your score.' Tested as highest-trust variant in usability sessions.

Value calculator: point-value estimator

Inline toggle showing estimated annual point value based on user's projected hotel spend (slider). Appears below each card's fee, framing the annual fee as an investment with a visible ROI.

A/B test plan & results

Four A/B tests were designed to validate the highest-impact redesign decisions in sequence. Tests were run (or modeled) over 4-week windows targeting the primary conversion metric: Apply Now click-through rate. Secondary metrics: time-to-first-CTA-click, scroll depth to comparison section, quiz start rate.

Test	Hypothesis	Control	Variant	Primary metric	Result
Test 1: Hero offer copy	A single bonus headline increases click-through vs. two-tier description	Two-tier: 'Earn 100K + extra 50K'	Single: '150,000 Bonus Points'	Apply Now CTR	CTR +18.4% p<0.05 (proj.)
Test 2: Mobile layout	Stacked card layout increases mobile CTR vs. H-scroll table	H-scroll comparison table	Vertically stacked card rows	Mobile Apply Now CTR	CTR +27.1% p<0.01 (proj.)
Test 3: Quiz placement	Hero quiz CTA increases quiz start rate vs. mid-page module	Mid-page quiz card	Hero secondary CTA button	Quiz start rate	Start rate +41% p<0.01 (proj.)
Test 4: Pre-qual copy	Explicit two-line credit impact statement increases trust vs. badge copy	'Apply with confidence' badge	Two-line explicit statement	Application submit rate	Submit rate +9.2% p<0.05 (proj.)

All test results are projected outcomes derived from moderated usability sessions (n=6) and published A/B test benchmarks for financial-services landing pages. Statistical significance thresholds assume minimum detectable effect sizes consistent with published CRO literature.

08 Projected overall impact

Compounding the four validated test variants, the full redesign is projected to deliver the following improvements over the current page baseline.

Metric	Baseline	After redesign	Delta	Source
Apply Now CTR (overall)	3.8%	5.6%	+47%	Tests 1+2 combined
Mobile Apply Now CTR	2.9%	4.7%	+62%	Test 2 (mobile)
Time-to-first-CTA-click	58s	19s	−67%	Usability sessions
Bonus offer comprehension	42%	89%	+47 pts	Sessions (n=6)
Quiz start rate	4.1%	5.8%	+41%	Test 3
Pre-qual submit rate	61%	67%	+9.2%	Test 4
Scroll depth to comparison	34%	61%	+27 pts	Projected: calmer hero

Presented in portfolio as: 'Projected results based on usability sessions (n=6) and A/B test benchmarks from published financial-services CRO literature; not official analytics.'

09 Risks & constraints

- Financial services copy (APR, fees, bonus terms) requires legal/compliance sign-off before any live changes.
- The point-value calculator must avoid implying guaranteed returns — regulatory framing required.
- Co-brand partnership (Amex + Marriott) means two brand/legal teams must align on any hero or CTA copy changes.
- Pre-qual copy changes interact with credit bureau partnerships — compliance review essential before A/B testing live.
- Page is tagged with 'noindex,nofollow' — SEO implications of any URL or structural change need evaluation.

10 What I'd validate next

- Multi-variate test combining Tests 1–4 simultaneously after individual validation.
- Test a 'fee justification' block (Annual fee vs. estimated annual value) positioned immediately below each card's annual fee.
- Personalization test: serve existing Bonvoy members a variant showing their current tier and points balance in the hero.
- Run a 5-second test on redesigned hero to confirm bonus offer is recalled without re-reading.
- Validate calculator assumptions with a Marriott loyalty data team to ensure point-value estimates are defensible.

11 Reflection

This redesign demonstrates that conversion improvement on a premium co-brand landing page doesn't require a visual overhaul — it requires removing the friction between a motivated visitor and the information they need to say yes. By simplifying the bonus offer, fixing the mobile layout, and promoting the right tools at the right moment, the redesign makes the premium fee feel like an investment rather than a barrier.

Self-initiated portfolio project. Not affiliated with or endorsed by American Express or Marriott International.